

It's easy to get an Access Point or router and set up a connection, but that can be pretty expensive

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Don't you wish you could access stuff on your PC—and indeed, your broadband connection—from your laptop, without going through the hassles and the mess of metres of wires?

It's very easy to get an Access Point or router and set up a connection, but remember it can be pretty expensive.

The following is a step-by-step explanation of how you can turn your Wi-Fi card into an Access Point, and thus share data and an Internet connection over it.

What's more, this is no tougher than taking time out on a lazy weekend to go shopping for an expensive and wholly unnecessary device!

Setting Up A Wi-Fi Card As An Access Point

Access points cost over Rs 5,000—an investment that doesn't make sense for a very small setup of, say, two PCs. There are cheaper alternatives that will be easier on your pocket. By 'cheaper alternative', we mean Wi-Fi cards, which can be PCMCIA-based for laptops, or PCI-based for desktops.

In the following steps, we take you through the process of configuring a Wi-Fi card as an Access Point to which wireless clients can connect—and subsequently share an Internet connection and access shared resources.

We used the SMC2802W PCI-based Wi-Fi card plugged into a desktop PC. It was configured as an Access Point to which Wi-Fi clients connected.

STEP 1 Installing The Card
Switch off your system and remove the side cover. Locate an empty

PCI slot. Plug in the Wi-Fi card. Close the cabinet and attach the detachable antenna to the card.

Since Wi-Fi uses radio signals, line of sight is not an issue—but at the same time, make sure that the antenna is not in a corner; this might affect performance.

STEP Installing The Drivers

Boot the system, and the card will be detected. Install the driver and utility that comes on the CD. You might have to restart the machine depending on the driver's requirements.

STEP The Configuration Utility

The utility installed for the card is where you can do most of the setup from. Since different manufacturers design their utilities differently, you will have to look at the different tabs on your card's utility to get the hang of it. It's pretty simple with most cards—you can initialise the configuration/monitoring utility from the 'Start Menu' or from the Taskbar.

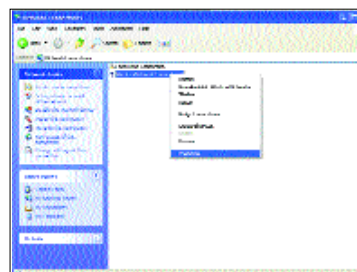


Configuring your Wi-Fi card

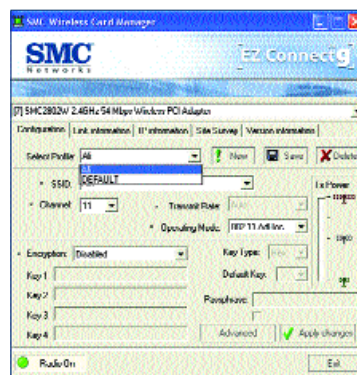
STEP 4 Create A New Profile

In the utility, you will need to create a new

profile. Give it an appropriate name, and under the SSID field, type in "New SSID", or anything else. Leave the channel to its default value, which is 11 in most cases if you have just one Wi-Fi setup. Save this profile and exit the utility.



View your network properties



Creating a Wi-Fi profile

STEP Producing An IP Address

You will need to give the network an IP address. To do this, go to the 'Control Panel' and click the 'Network Connections' tab. Select 'Wireless Connection' and right-click it.

In the window that pops up, click 'Properties'. This will open a new 'Wireless Network Connection Properties' window, where you'll see a TCP/IP field.

Highlight it and click the 'Properties' button. This will open a window where you can assign the IP address, subnet mask and DNS server.

